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By **KIRO 7 News Staff**
March 30, 2026 at 7:02 pm
PDT

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Pierce County Sheriff's Office deactivate s its automated license plate readers



By **KIRO 7 News Staff**

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PIERCE COUNTY, Wash. — The Pierce County Sheriff's Office says it has deactivated its Automated License Plate Reader (ALPR) system, commonly known as Flock cameras.

The move is in response to the recent signing of the "Driver Privacy Act" by Governor Bob Ferguson.

The law, passed by the Washington State Legislature earlier this month, establishes strict new regulations governing the use of ALPR technology by law enforcement agencies.

It prohibits the use of license plate readers in proximity to community locations, including hospitals, schools, and other protected areas. Violations of these restrictions carry significant legal consequences, including classification as a gross misdemeanor for individual officers.

At this time, there is no available technology or operational capability that allows the Sheriff's Office to ensure that ALPR cameras can reliably differentiate between restricted and permitted locations in real time. As a result, the department feels that continuing to use it would place its deputies at risk of unintentionally violating state law.

"Sheriff Keith Swank informs the community this decision was not made lightly," the department shared on Monday. "The loss of this tool is a significant setback for public safety in our community. ALPR technology has been instrumental in locating missing persons, including Silver Alert cases, identifying stolen vehicles, and apprehending dangerous offenders. Without it, our ability to respond quickly and effectively is diminished."

The Pierce County Sheriff's Office also acknowledged that broader concerns surrounding privacy and the potential use of such technologies in connection with federal immigration enforcement, including issues related to Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), have contributed to the passage of this legislation.

“While the law intends to address those concerns, its practical impact at the local level is the removal of a critical investigative resource,” the department shared.

The Pierce County Sheriff’s Office said it will continue to explore lawful and effective alternatives to support its mission of keeping the public safe.

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